



THE APOSTLE OF THE APOSTLES

A RETREAT GUIDE ON
ST. MARY MAGDALENE

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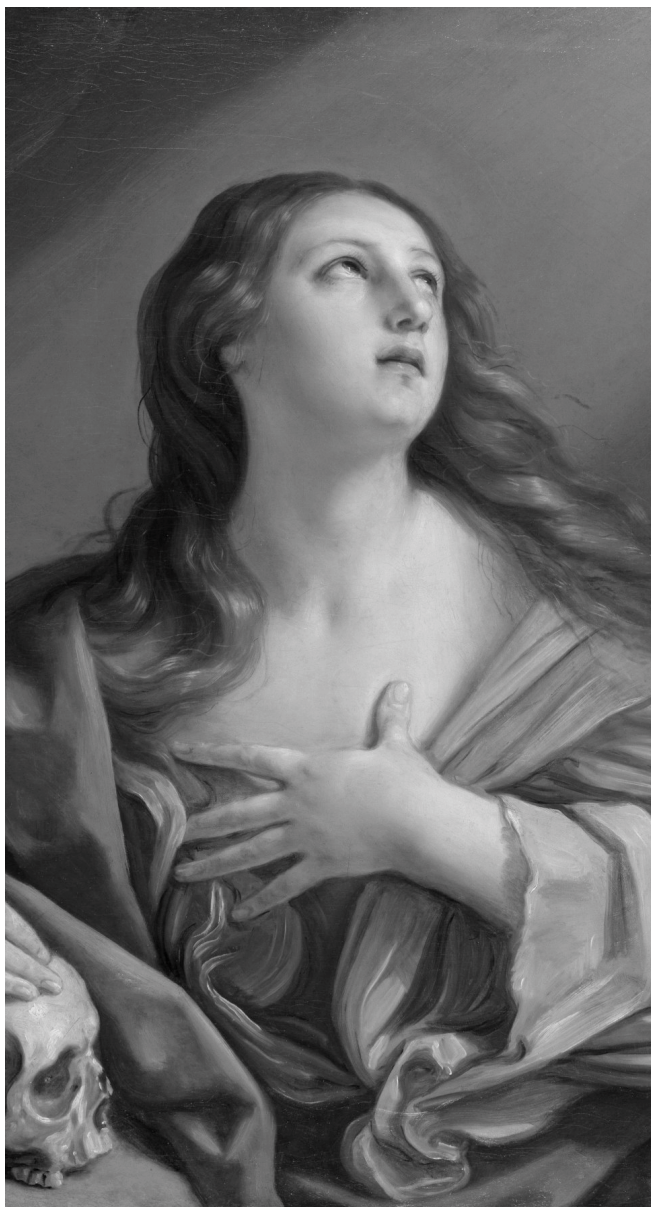
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INTRODUCTION

The Apostle of the Apostles



RETREAT OVERVIEW

On June 10th, 2016, Pope Francis did something unexpected: he raised St. Mary Magdalene's memorial on July 22nd to a feast in the Church's liturgical calendar.

Except for feasts of Our Lord and Our Lady, the title "feast" is normally reserved to feast days of the Apostles. But the Holy Father wanted to point out that St. Mary Magdalene was, as St. Thomas Aquinas called her, "the apostle of the apostles." Christ chose her to tell his apostles the good news of his resurrection.

We can learn a great deal from her story. We can grow in our relationship with the Lord she loved so much by reflecting on her life. And by her example and her intercession, we can become more joyful and committed witnesses to the risen Christ in our own lives too.

We'll follow this path for our Easter Retreat with St. Mary Magdalene:

- In the first meditation we'll consider how St. Mary Magdalene sought Christ, and, above all, how she was sought by him.
- In the second meditation we'll reflect about how Christ definitively found St. Mary Magdalene—but not in the way she expected.
- And finally, in the conference, we'll look at several ways we can grow in our own calling to be apostles of Christ's resurrection.

And now let's open our hearts and our minds to the Holy Spirit, preparing ourselves to receive his inspiration and his love. St. Mary Magdalene, pray for us!

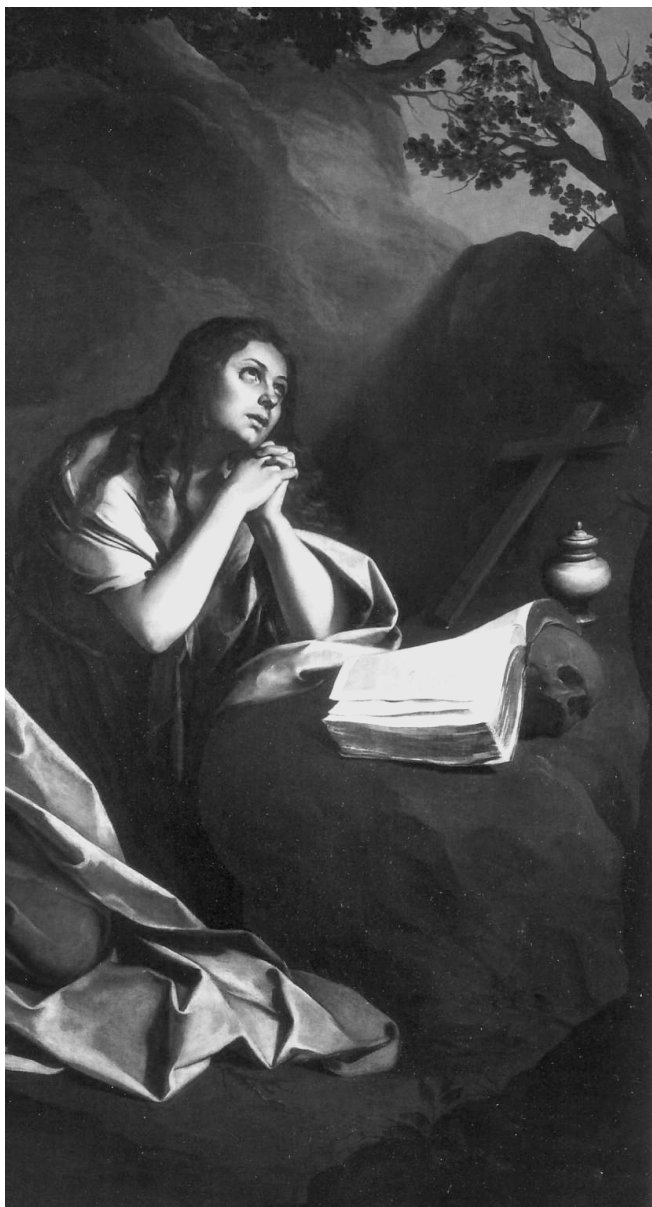
FIRST MEDITATION

Sought

“On the first day of the week, Mary of Magdala came to the tomb early in the morning, while it was still dark, and saw the stone removed from the tomb... And as she wept, she bent over into the tomb and saw two angels in white sitting there, one at the head and one at the feet where the Body of Jesus had been. And they said to her, “Woman, why are you weeping?” She said to them, “They have taken my Lord, and I don’t know where they laid him.”

—John 20:1; 11–13

NEW AMERICAN BIBLE



INTRODUCTION

They say that Rabbi Baruch, a famous 19th century rabbi, once saw his young grandson crying. He asked him the cause of his sadness, and his grandson replied that he had been playing hide and seek with a friend but the game had gone terribly wrong. “I hid,” he told his grandfather, “but my friend didn’t come to look for me.” At that Rabbi Baruch himself began to weep and exclaimed “How often God must say the same thing. ‘I hide, but no one comes to look for me.’”

St. Mary Magdalene, though, was different. She searched for God even when the search seemed hopeless. Who was this woman? We actually don’t know too much about her. She was likely from Magdala, a Roman garrison town in Galilee known for its immorality. St. Luke tells us that Jesus had cast out seven demons from her, and St. Augustine surmises that perhaps this stands for the 7 deadly sins. There is also a tradition that she was a prostitute, and that she is both the woman saved by Jesus after being caught in adultery, and the woman who washed Jesus’ feet with her tears and dried them with her hair. In any case, like all of us, she was a great sinner washed in the merciful love of the Lord—and his love for her filled her with a great love for him.

She would have understood St. John of the Cross’s beautiful lines addressed to God in the *Spiritual Canticle*: “When you looked at me, your eyes imprinted your grace in me; for this you loved me ardently... Now truly you can look at me, since you have looked and left in me grace and beauty.”

Her love for Christ brought her to the foot of the cross when nearly all his other followers fled. And now we find her searching for his body.

THE SEARCH

Our God can seem to be a hidden God; he is so real that his presence is mysterious to us. Like the sun that shines so brightly that if we look at it we only see darkness, God can appear elusive, shrouded, concealed. It's not an accident that Jesus tells us to search: "Seek and you shall find..." (Matthew 7:7)

But something very beautiful is at play here. St. John of the Cross reminds us: "In the first place, it should be known that if anyone is seeking God, the Beloved is seeking that person much more." Our desire for God is a response to his desire for us.

And so St. Mary Magdalene went to search for Jesus. She knew he was dead. She saw him die on the cross. But her love could not forget. She could not let go of him.

St. Gregory the Great writes that her love was so great that "She was still seeking the one she had not found, and while she sought she wept; burning with the fire of love, she longed for him who she thought had been taken away."

She didn't know that it was Christ himself who had inspired this longing within her heart. But she followed this longing back to its source, the pierced heart of the Crucified Christ.

THE TOMB

And so she came to the tomb. She came while it was still dark. Note the paradox here: it was Easter morning, and it was still dark. In our own lives darkness and light also mingle. We live in a redeemed world, but sometimes it is

still very, very dark. Somehow, mysteriously, this is part of God's plan. Even Easter doesn't simply wash away all darkness—not yet.

But Mary didn't turn back. She came to the tomb. Think about the courage this must have taken. The tomb was a symbol of all her fears and anxieties. The person she loved more than anyone else in the world was buried in this tomb. He was the one who forgave her and loved her and set her free. And now he was gone. But she still bent down and looked into the tomb. God's love in her soul gave her the strength to look squarely at her deepest fear.

And she found something strange. The stone was rolled away from the tomb. There's a deep lesson here for all of us. We cannot save ourselves. We can only receive forgiveness and salvation as a gift. We wait for the Lord to roll away the stone, in his own time. But we also have to wait in his presence. He asks us to cooperate by showing up, by longing, by seeking.

STILL LOOKING

The tomb was empty though, and Christ's body was not there. Even this last consolation seemed to be taken from her. Her grief and her passion to find the Lord were so great that even the appearance of two angels didn't make her stop and think that something remarkable had just occurred. And so she kept searching. She did not give up.

At times we can get impatient with God because our desires seem unfulfilled. We may be tempted to ask him "Lord, I believe that you've inspired these good desires in me—why are they still frustrated?" St. Mary Magdalene

must have had the same thought as she kept searching for Jesus. And St. Gregory the Great offers this helpful reflection. “At first she sought but did not find, but when she persevered it happened that she found what she was looking for. When our desires are not satisfied, they grow stronger, and becoming stronger they take hold of their object.” He adds, “Holy desires likewise grow with anticipation...”

In the next meditation we will prayerfully reflect on how St. Mary Magdalene was found by the Lord she loved so deeply. But for now, let’s take some time to pray about all of this. Let’s ask the Holy Spirit to open the eyes and the ears of our hearts so that we can hear his voice calling us to search, because we are already sought.

The following questions and quotations might help your personal prayer.

QUESTIONS FOR PERSONAL REFLECTION/GROUP DISCUSSION

1. At times God seems to hide so that we look for him. In what ways is the Lord asking me to search for him right now?
2. What or where is my own “tomb?” And how does Jesus want to help me to look into that by the power of his merciful love?
3. What are my deepest and holiest desires?

QUOTATIONS TO HELP YOUR PRAYER

“Jesus thirsts; his asking arises from the depths of God’s desire for us... God thirsts that we may thirst for him.

—*Catechism of the Catholic Church*, #2560

“By withdrawing, God allows himself to be discovered. Hiding himself, he allows himself to be found. By refusing himself, he surrenders.

—St. Hedwig of Antwerp

“As a human being, you are a thirst (noun, not adjective). Every single choice you make all day long is proof that you seek, you desire, you want, you lack. Nothing is ever enough... You are engaged in an endless whirl. Always you seek, desire, want, lack. Nothing is enough: not praise, not success, not youth, not love. You are a thirst in the flesh, an incarnated thirst. You yearn for endless beauty and joy, endless love and delight, endless security and happiness—and an immortality in which to enjoy it all. You cannot help being an incarnate thirst. Nor can I. We were born that way and we will die that way...

—*You Are Christ’s*, by Fr. Thomas Dubay

SECOND MEDITATION

Found

“She turned around and saw Jesus there, but did not know it was Jesus. Jesus said to her, “Woman, why are you weeping? Whom are you looking for?” She thought it was the gardener and said to him, “Sir, if you carried him away, tell me where you laid him, and I will take him.” Jesus said to her, “Mary!” She turned and said to him in Hebrew, “Rabbouni,” which means Teacher. Jesus said to her, “Stop holding on to me, for I have not yet ascended to the Father. But go to my brothers and tell them, ‘I am going to my Father and your Father, to my God and your God.’” Mary went and announced to the disciples, “I have seen the Lord,” and then reported what he had told her.

—John 20:14–18

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INTRODUCTION

God is always a mystery. We can't predict him. We can't control him. We don't determine the conditions of our relationship with him. All we can do is open ourselves to receive the gift and then respond with gratitude and with love. And St. Mary Magdalene experienced this as the rosy tints of dawn filled the sky on that first Easter morning.

SHE DID NOT KNOW IT WAS JESUS

In the last meditation we pondered her search for the body of Jesus. She is still searching, and as she turned from the empty tomb she saw Jesus but did not know who it was. Let's pause there. Often Jesus comes in disguise, and we don't recognize him. In fact, he is always acting in our lives and in the lives of those around us, and he invites us to learn to discover his loving presence in all circumstances.

St. Mary Magdalene also had to learn to recognize his risen presence. She expected him to look and act in a certain way; but he wanted to give her a new vision, the vision of faith which sees the invisible in the visible, which finds God in all things and, especially, in all people. And even when we fail to recognize him, Jesus doesn't give up.

St. Mary Magdalene thought he was the gardener; in fact, according to the saints, Jesus is the gardener. He is the gardener of our souls, who came to bring us life, and life to the full. And he is about to do exactly that for this woman who loved him so much and sought him so eagerly.

WHY ARE YOU WEEPING? WHOM DO YOU SEEK?

Jesus often begins his conversations with us with a question. “Who do you say that I am? Do you believe that I can do this? What do you want me to do for you?” He does this because he loves the sound of our voice. He does this because he wants a relationship with us, and he wants us to share our hearts with him just as he shares his heart with us.

And so he asked Mary Magdalene “Why are you weeping? Whom do you seek?” It’s important to imagine Jesus’ voice as he asked her these questions. Tenderness, concern, and reassurance must have blended together in a way that gave her the courage to blurt out: ““Sir, if you carried him away, tell me where you laid him, and I will take him.”

St. Gregory the Great’s reflection on this is very beautiful. He writes: “She is asked why she is sorrowing so that her desire might be strengthened; for when she mentions whom she is seeking, her love is kindled all the more ardently.” In other words, St. Mary Magdalene needed to hear herself say what’s stirring in her heart.

This is why honesty is so important in our prayer. The Lord doesn’t want to know us as we think we should be. He wants us to let him know us as we really are. When we pour out our hearts to him we might not receive the answer we think we need. But God has something even better in store, as St. Mary Magdalene was about to discover.

MARY!

This man in front of her did not tell her where he had put the body. Rather he spoke one single word, a word which meant more to her than the entire universe. Jesus looked at her, and with all the creative power of eternal love he said “Mary!” Mary of Magdala, a notorious sinner, a former prostitute, is the first one to hear her own name in the new creation. Easter Sunday does not change our names. Easter Sunday does not erase our past. Easter Sunday redeems and makes all things new.

And so Jesus said “Mary!” Once again, St. Gregory shares a wonderful insight when he writes “He calls her by name, as though he were saying: ‘Recognize me as I recognize you; for I do not know you as I know others; I know you as yourself.’” Everyone who seeks will be found.

We are not numbers to God. Each one of us is created out of love, and for love, and our names are precious to him. And at the sound of her name coming from the lips of Jesus, Mary recognized him. She, the seeker, had been found.

STOP HOLDING ON TO ME

And then Jesus said something that seems strange and perhaps even a little heartless. “Stop holding on to me, for I have not yet ascended to the Father.” At the moment of Mary’s greatest joy, he seems to push her away. Why?

St. Mary Magdalene must have thought what anyone would think. She must have imagined that the cross was just a nightmare and that now she could return to

the wonderful days before the crucifixion, when she accompanied Jesus and the apostles and provided food and money. But Jesus is teaching her not to cling to her idea of who he should be. The Cross is not just a bad dream for her to forget. The Cross has become the revelation of love: in his life, in her life, and in our lives. With his words, Jesus was creating space for this new understanding of who he was. He was creating space in her heart for a new depth of love.

Because of the Paschal Mystery, Jesus has a new relationship with Mary and with each one of us. We see him now through the eyes of faith. We know him by faith. Mary could not hold on to Jesus, because, through the Holy Spirit, he would be present to her in a far deeper way than when she listened to his words in Galilee.

When Jesus said “Stop holding on to me,” he was asking Mary a question. “Will you trust me? Will you trust me enough to surrender your memories and your plans to me? We can’t go back before the Paschal Mystery—I have something infinitely more wonderful for you and for all those I love.”

GO TO MY BROTHERS

And then Jesus gave her a mission. He told her: “Go to my brothers and tell them, ‘I am going to my Father and your Father, to my God and your God.’” These are powerful words. Since the sin of our first parents we had been estranged from God, and we were unable to restore that relationship. Now, on Easter Sunday morning, Jesus told Mary Magdalene that we have become God’s new family, and that she would be the first person to share this earth-shattering news with the apostles.

God's ways are not our ways, nor are his thoughts our thoughts. Christ chose a repentant prostitute and not, say, the Blessed Virgin Mary or St. John the Evangelist to tell his apostles that he had risen from the dead. Moreover, in Jesus' day, a woman's word had no legal weight and women could not be witnesses in official matters. In an instant Jesus shattered those social conventions and sent Mary Magdalene as the Apostle of the Apostles.

In the conference we'll ponder this mission and relate it to our own lives. For now, though, let's take some time to speak with our Lord about everything we've just considered. The following questions and quotations may help your personal prayer.

QUESTIONS FOR PERSONAL REFLECTION/GROUP DISCUSSION

1. How is Jesus disguised in my own life? Where (and especially, in whom) does he want me to recognize him?
2. St. Mary Magdalene recognized the Lord when he said her name. What do I hear when Jesus says my name?
3. Where am I most tempted to "hold on" to my own idea of Jesus? What does he want to say to me in that?

QUOTATIONS TO HELP YOUR PRAYER



Incline your ear and come to me, hear, that your soul may live; and I will make with you an everlasting covenant, my steadfast, merciful love for David. Behold, I made him a witness to the peoples, a

leader and commander for the peoples. Behold, you shall call nations that you know not, and nations that knew you not shall run to you, because of the Lord, your God, and of the Holy One of Israel, for he has glorified you.

—Isaiah 55:3–5

RSVCE

“For my thoughts are not your thoughts, neither are your ways my ways, says the Lord. For as the heavens are higher than the earth, so are my ways higher than your ways, and my thoughts than your thoughts. For as the rain and the snow come down from heaven, and do not return there but water the earth, making it bring forth and sprout, giving seed to the sower and bread to the eater, so shall my word be that goes forth from my mouth; it shall not return to me empty, but it shall accomplish that which I intend, and prosper in the thing for which I sent it.

—Isaiah 55:8–11

RSVCE

“Seeking the face of God in everything, everyone, all the time, and his hand in every happening; This is what it means to be contemplative in the heart of the world. Seeing and adoring the presence of Jesus, especially in the lowly appearance of bread, and in the distressing disguise of the poor.

—Mother Teresa of Calcutta

CONFERENCE

Sent



INTRODUCTION

In some sense, St. Mary Magdalene is a paradigm for every Christian life. She was a great sinner who received the Lord's merciful love. That forgiveness created in her a living memory of mercy, which drew her to love him and follow him with all her heart, soul, mind and strength. Through her participation in the Paschal Mystery she came to know the Lord more deeply, and then he sent her to tell others the joyful news that he is risen.

In our own way, each one of us is also called to a similar experience. We too are sought by Christ. We too are found by his love. And we too are sent to proclaim that love to others.

WHAT IS AN APOSTLE?

St. Thomas Aquinas called St. Mary Magdalene "The Apostle of the Apostles." But what, exactly, is an apostle? In Greek, the language in which the New Testament was written, "apostle" means someone who is sent. (In fact the Latinate equivalent is "missionary.")

Granted, the term applies most fully to the Twelve Apostles chosen by Christ as the pillars of the Church, and to those who share in their mission through the sacrament of Holy Orders. Yet the sacrament of confirmation, in particular, gives every Christian a share in that same mission.

The Catechism reminds us that Confirmation "gives us a special strength in the Holy Spirit to spread and defend the faith by word and action as true witnesses to Christ, to

confess the name of Christ boldly, and never to be ashamed of the Cross” (*Catechism of the Catholic Church*, #1303).

Christ chose St. Mary Magdalene to proclaim his resurrection to St. Peter, St. James, St. John and the other apostles. In some way, we all share a similar calling to tell others that Christ has risen from the dead.

THE SOURCE OF OUR CONFIDENCE

It isn't always easy. It wasn't easy for St. Mary Magdalene to tell the apostles about the Resurrection. She doubtless felt completely inadequate. She must have wondered, “Who am I that this should be entrusted to me? What if I don't get it right? What if they don't believe me? What if they throw my past back in my face? What if they point out that I'm uneducated? What if...”

In that moment, though, she must have remembered who had sent her. This was not her message. It was Christ's. And that's equally true for us. When we feel inadequate, it's important to bring those thoughts and feelings to the Lord. When we hold them up to him, and test them by his light, we realize that we can do all things through him who gives us strength (cf. Philippians 4:13).

Now let's briefly look at four ways to live our calling to be apostles.

PRAYER, THE HEART OF THE APOSTOLATE

The first way is prayer. An apostle's most important relationship is the relationship with God. We're not sharing an idea, a strategy, or a fitness program: we're sharing a person, Jesus Christ, crucified and risen.

Therefore, our relationship with him is paramount. When we find that we're anxious and stressed about sharing Christ's love with others, it's probably because we've forgotten the why behind the what. Being an apostle is meant to be something like a pitcher of water. The pitcher is constantly filled with the water of God's love, and that water overflows to others.

Another way that prayer is at the heart of our apostolate (our mission) is our prayer for others. Every time we pray, we are drawing others closer to God. Every time we go to Mass, if we try to remember that we're entering the mystery of Christ's love we're drawing the world closer to God. Every time we go to confession, we are releasing new love into the world.

Imagine throwing a stone into a still pool of water. The ripples spread over the face of the waters and create wonderful new patterns. In the same way, from the silence of our communion with the Living God in prayer we are living out the call to be apostles.

BEING PRESENT

A second way to live out the call to be apostles is through our presence. The First Letter of St. Peter encourages us to always be ready to give a reason for the hope that is in us (1 Peter 3:15). That obviously implies that we're not removed from the world around us with its hopes and its fears.

It's easy to worry and complain about the way the world is today. Wars, cruelty, injustice, social mayhem, gender confusion—the list goes on and on. But Christ looks straight at us and asks, "What are we—you and I together—going to do about it?" God doesn't make mistakes, and we were born for precisely this moment in history.

BEING ATTENTIVE

The third way to live out our call to be apostles is to be attentive. Christ was always attentive to every opportunity to share his Father's love with others. He related everything to his mission: the birds of the sky, the flowers in the field, fishermen, farmers, tax collectors. He thought and spoke from a place of prayer and was able to relate everything to God's word.

We all have dozens of daily opportunities to be an apostle of Christ. It might be through something we say (or refrain from saying). It might be another of the corporal or spiritual works of mercy. It might be talking about Jesus with your kids. It might be asking a question to try to understand a friend's point of view. It might be a text message to assure someone of your prayers. Don't underestimate these little ways of being an apostle.

It's also important to be attentive to consistent stirrings in our hearts to undertake something for the Lord. Perhaps he's calling us to a deeper commitment to spreading the good news of his love and resurrection. If we're attentive to those stirrings, which may come in prayer or through the circumstances of our lives, he will act.

BEING INVITING

The fourth way to live out this call is by being inviting. We don't impose anything; we simply invite. Mary Magdalene didn't run and tell the apostles: "Christ is risen, and if you don't believe this right away he'll smite you." She just shared her experience and told them what he had told her. It was an invitation, not an imposition.

As far as I know, no one ever became a Christian because he or she was humiliated in an argument. Instead of fighting, let's try inviting. Why not invite someone to go on a retreat (or to watch an RC Retreat Guide)? Why not invite someone to go to confession? Why not invite someone to go to Mass? Why not invite a neighbor over for dinner?

Christ invited Mary Magdalene into freedom and life. For her, to be an apostle simply meant sharing that same good news with others.

CONCLUSION

Jesus spoke these words to St. Mary Magdalene: "Go and tell my brothers." And she did, becoming the Apostle of the Apostles. Today he tells us the same thing. "Go and tell my brothers... Go and tell my sisters..."

It's not complicated. It's a new way of seeing the world which comes to us through God's grace. And the results are incalculable. In fact, we are Christians because someone else shared the faith with us. And each one of us is meant to be a link in the chain of grace extending throughout the centuries.

Hopefully this Easter Retreat with St. Mary Magdalene, the Apostle of the Apostles, has helped us to deepen in our own identity as a seeker who is sought by God. And in the joy of the Risen Christ, may we commit to sharing his love with others. In the words of the collect from the feast of St. Mary Magdalene:

“O God, whose Only Begotten Son entrusted Mary Magdalene before all others with announcing the great joy of the Resurrection, grant, we pray, that through her intercession and example we may proclaim the living Christ and come to see him reigning in your glory. Who lives and reigns with you in the unity of the Holy Spirit, one God, for ever and ever. Amen!

The following questions may assist in discerning where the Lord is leading us after this retreat.

PERSONAL QUESTIONNAIRE

1. What are the most apparent ways the Lord is asking me to be an apostle right now?
2. To whom, specifically, is he sending me?
3. What are the greatest fears I face in that, and how does God want to speak to those fears?
4. What are the greatest external challenges I face in that, and how does God want to speak to those challenges?
5. How present am I as a Christian in the world? What's one way I could be more present this week?
6. How attentive am I to opportunities to share Christ's love with others? What's one way I could be more attentive this week?
7. What is one invitation I could extend to someone this week?
8. Who could help me to discern the answer to the previous questions (perhaps a spiritual director, a family member, or a friend)?

FURTHER READING

If you feel moved to continue reflecting and praying about this theme, you may find the following books helpful:

The Soul of the Apostolate,
by Dom Jean-Baptiste Chautard.

*Go! 30 Meditations on How to Best Love
Your Neighbor as Yourself,* by Fr. John Bartunek, LC

Story of a Soul, by St. Therese of Lisieux

*Christifideles laici (On the Vocation and Mission
of the Lay Faithful in the Church),* by St. John Paul II.

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